

NOT ANOTHER WORD

A man who said the world would be better off without him, taken at his word.

Based on the life of Hunter S. Thompson.

The Story

MILES GOODMAN wakes at three in the afternoon, and the first thing he reaches for is not the coffee.

He is a gonzo journalist at the end of his usefulness — famous enough that strangers send their children over for an autograph, tired enough that he signs it and asks the boy to stay honest, because honesty *"will get you about half way there most of the time."* His days run on a ritual so fixed it has become a kind of religion: Chivas before the kettle boils, a cigarette chosen from a wooden box, cocaine out of a carved dragon he was given on a mountain in Yunnan twenty years ago, the radio news, one enormous meal eaten alone in the corner booth at Asters, then the study — typewriter, acid, a VHS looping in the corner — and writing until a red cardinal lands on the windowsill at dawn.

NOT ANOTHER WORD plays that ritual three times, and lets it come apart.

On the first day it is almost enviable. On the second the pages stop coming, and Miles leaves a voicemail quitting the book, the Paramount deal and the next project, telling his agent it's time to retreat to Aspen. That night the cardinal doesn't sing.

On the third day the world has quietly rearranged itself around him. There is a white van parked across the street with a logo nobody can quite read. His cleaner sees it and makes a phone call. The bandage on his forehead has been changed by someone else's hands. Every window opposite has its curtains drawn. And at Asters, where he has eaten every night for years, his booth is taken and the room is half empty and Joansy — who has always been kind to him — will not seat him and cannot say why.

JOANSY: We're not supposed to be expecting you.

Then the interview crew arrives: a woman named Stacey Bradshaw, and two men who are both called Michael.

The interview is the best conversation Miles has had in months, and he talks himself into the trap without any help at all. He explains that the myth has outgrown him, that he keeps appearing inside his own stories, that he has become an appendage to his reputation. *"It would be much better if I died, so people could take the myth."*

Stacey asks him, evenly, whether he would be happier dead.

Then she takes a newspaper out of her bag and asks him to turn to page three, where his own obituary sits beside a photograph of him on a boat in Lombok, twenty years and one lifetime ago.

STACEY: It's tomorrow's paper.

The Michaels stop being crew. One kneels beside him with a stethoscope. The other holds him in the chair.

The reveal. Miles has been selected by Sidman's Retirement Facility — an exclusive service that identifies important voices who have lost their tune, stages their deaths, and administers their legacies. The overdose will run on every network by morning. The unfinished work has already been collected and will be released, in the correct order, to give the career the ending it deserves. *"The ultimate reward without having to pay the ultimate price."*

They do not kill him. They agree with him. That is the horror.

Form. 32 pages, 47 scenes, approximately 30 minutes. One apartment, one pub, three days. Two flashbacks. A small cast and a single principal location.

Why it works. The film never has to argue its theme, because its protagonist argues it himself, on camera, to the people who have come to enforce it. The trap is built entirely out of things Miles says voluntarily.

Note. The script currently carries two alternate endings — one that stays outside on the street with the body bag and the van, one that follows him into the welcome room and the chairman's handshake. Both are written. Choosing between them is the next creative decision.

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